

Mixed Nuts: Rules

README (important)

These are the most recent as of 2025/12/07.

Some rules are still in flux. BEFORE PLAYING: decide on which variant(s) you will be going with.

Intro

You are in packaging at Acme Nut Co. Over four seasons of gameplay you jockey with other workers to grab a range of nuts (and other surprises) as they come out of the conveyor belt, trying to build sets of matching types which can be packaged and shipped. But beware: your workspace is tiny, and if leftover nuts start to spill over your salary will be docked. And watch out for that Bad Nut!

Setup

Shuffle the deck of cards.

Each player draws cards from the deck until they get a Peanut, Almond, or Cashew. They keep this “basic nut” card as their starting hand. Any other cards that were drawn are shuffled back into the deck.

Gameplay

The game is played in four seasons, followed by final scoring.

Playing a Season

Create the Conveyor Belt

Lay out a row of cards from the deck to form the conveyor belt. The number of cards to use depends on season number and number of players:

Season 1	Season 2	Season 3	Season 4
5 cards per player	5 cards per player	5 cards per player	7 cards per player

The final card in the row should be placed face down; all the other cards should be face up.

If possible keep the cards in a single row: if you run out of room use multiple rows or “snake” the row back and forth.

Acquire Cards Through Bidding

Players consider the cards available at the beginning (leftmost) end of the conveyor belt and decide how many cards they would like to acquire.

To bid, each player places all their tokens in their left hand, then secretly moves their bid into their right hand.

Once everyone has selected their bid, bids are revealed. The player with the LOWEST bid wins: they take the bid number of cards from the left hand side of the conveyor belt and these cards to their hand.

Note: tokens used for a bid are not spent or lost.

The player who acquired cards is now “out” for the rest of the round: they cannot bid again, and cannot acquire any more cards.

Every player who is still “in” proceeds with another round of bidding, using the same rules (secret bids, lowest bidder takes the bid number of cards from the left hand side of the belt and is then “out”).

When only one player is left, they must take all the cards remaining on the conveyor belt, including the final upside down “mystery” card.

Nil Bid

A player may put zero tokens in his right hand, thereby bidding “nil”. This is a special bid: they are opting out of this round of bidding, and they are not considered when evaluating the lowest bid. A player who bids nil is free to participate in later auctions in the same round.

Ties

If there is not a single lowest bid (either because all bids are Nil or there’s a tie for lowest), remove and discard the leftmost card on the belt and run the auction again.

Package

Once all the cards for the season have been divided up, players enter the “Package” phase. Players remove matching sets of nuts from their hand, placing each set face down to their right.

Face down sets should be kept separate so that other players may see how many packages a player has shipped.

Different nut types have different requirements to build a set, as indicated on the card:

- Peanut, Almond or Cashew: exactly 3 matching Cards form a Set.
- Macadamia: exactly 4 cards form a Set.

Cleanup

Players are allowed to keep up to 3 cards in their hand to use in the next round. Any excess cards must be placed on the "Floor": cards are placed face down, each separated from the other so other players may see how many Floor cards a player has.

Special Cards

Bad Nut

A Bad Nut will cost a player 2 Coins if it is on the Floor at the end of the game. A player may opt to hold the Bad Nut in their hand instead of discarding it to the Floor. It cannot be shipped as part of any Package.

Squirrel

As soon as a player draws the Squirrel, they must discard 2 nut cards (Peanut, Almond, Cashew, or Macadamia) cards from their hand. If they have fewer than 2 such cards they discard as many as they have. These cards are removed from the game (they are **not** placed on the player's Floor). The Squirrel card is then also removed from the game.

Bonus Cards

Gold bordered cards unique bonuses:

- Honey Roasted: Play during Packaging, adding the card to the set of matching Nut cards. Adds a bonus which scales based on Nut type (see card)
- Raisin: Play during Packaging. Can be used to substitute for a Peanut, Almond, or Cashew. May NOT be used for a Macadamia.
- Hot Spice: Play during Packaging, placing it face up in the Package area. Adds 1 Coin for *all* that player's Packaged Peanuts during final scoring.
- Mixed Nuts: Play during Packaging. Place this card plus 1 Peanut, 1 Almond, 1 Cashew and 1 Macadamia in your Package area. This Package earns 5 Coins in final scoring.
- Broom: Play and discard during Cleanup. Remove and discard one card from your Floor.
- Gloves: Play and discard during Packaging. You may add a card from your Floor back into your hand.

- Coffee Break: Play and discard during Packaging. You and another player may exchange 1 card from your hands.

Game End and Final Scoring

The game ends after the fourth round.

Each player sets aside his hand (it is not used for final scoring), and flips their shipped Packages and Floor Cards.

Packages

Each Shipped Package scores Coins depending on the nut type, as indicated on the card:

- Peanut: +2 coins.
- Almond: +3 coins.
- Cashew: +4 coins.
- Macadamia: +7 coins.

Floor

First, set aside any Bad Nuts on the Floor: each Bad Nut card scores -2 Coins.

Then, for the remaining cards on the floor:

We are currently considering several variants on how to score the floor: agree on one before you begin play.

Variant A: Simple

Each card scores -1 Coin.

Variant B: Scaling by Type

Group the cards by “type”:

- Peanut
- Almond
- Cashew
- Macadamia
- Special

Then, for each group, the first card scores -1 Coin, the second -2 Coins, and so on.

So if a player ended the game with 3 Peanuts and a Macadamia on the Floor, they would lose

- 1 Coin for the first Peanut

- 2 Coins for the second Peanut
- 3 Coins for the third Peanut
- 1 Coin for the Macadamia

For a total of 7 Coins.

Highest score wins!

Tie Breakers

In Order

1. Most Packages Shipped
2. Fewest Cards on the Floor.
3. Shared Victory